

Introduction to Civics

Lecture 1

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Why do we Study Civics?

- To understand how the government works.
- To understand the processes the government uses to make decisions that affect all of us.
- To identify what your beliefs and values are, and thus how you will participate in society.
- To learn and practice basic citizenship skills.
- To identify and examine the challenges of participating in communities.
- To think about what active and responsible citizenship means to you.

What is Civics?

- Civics is the Prominent Social Science. Civics concerned with the study of government and the role played by the citizen to established a government.
- Civics is the study of the rights and duties of citizenship, focusing on the relationship between individuals and their government. It examines how government systems work, the roles and responsibilities of citizens, and the importance of civic engagement in maintaining a democratic society.
- Civics educates people on the structure of government at local, state, and federal levels, the electoral process, and how laws are made and enforced. It also emphasizes the significance of voting, participating in public affairs, and understanding one's role, in shaping public policy.
- By fostering civic knowledge and responsibility, civics encourages informed and active citizenship, which is crucial for the health and sustainability of democratic institutions.

- Understanding civics helps individuals advocate for their rights, engage in community service, and contribute to the betterment of society.
- According to the famous philosopher Aristotle, the man is a social animal.
- The very existence of human life depends upon mutual interaction and cooperation because many of his social and physical needs can only be met collectively. Consequently he develops a habit of cooperation with others and hence proves to be a good and helpful member of society.
- Hence, there is always a possibility of mutual conflict while collective and individual attempts are made to develop a society.
- Civics is bound to provide sense to man to maintain balance between the individual and the society and to develop healthy relationship between each other.
- This is Civics, which teaches us to develop a disciplined society.

Meaning and Origin of Civics

- The word Civics has been derived from two Latin words **CIVITAS & CIVIS**, which means **citizens or citizenship**. In modern usage, “**civics**” came to refer specifically to the study of **citizenship and government**.
- It means Civics is a discipline of knowledge dealing with day-to-day affairs of the state and its citizens.
- This connection to citizenship reflects the central focus of civics on the rights, duties, and responsibilities of individuals within a society or state.
- The term became widely used in the late 19th and early 20th centuries as formal education systems began to include civics as a subject to teach students about their role in society and the workings of their governments.

Citizen: A Citizen is a person who is a member of an organized political society or State, whether he dwells in a village or a city. And he is granted all types of rights and duties as a member of a State.

Civic Sense: People should be conscious of their obligations and responsibilities which may develop a beautiful and healthy society.

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City State: A City State is an independent and Sovereign city which serves as the centre of Political, economic and cultural life over its contiguous Territory.

- There were 158 City States in ancient Greece. Athens, Sparta, Corinth and Thebes were some famous City States of ancient Greece.
- Athens was a democratic City State where education, art, philosophy and dialogue was valued.
- Sparta was a military State where strength, size, power, war and fighting capabilities were most important.
- Ancient Greek developed first democratic government. Plato and Aristotle wrote about civics and importance of citizenship.
- In the middle ages, civics was crucial part of training who were going in the government of Churchill.
- In the Renaissance Scholars such as Niccolo Machiavelli and Jean Bodin wrote about the relationship of state and citizen.
- In the 18th century Philosophers such as Voltaire and Rousseau wrote about Democracy and the Rights of the Citizen.

Definitions of Civics:

CIVICS claims that an individual must be aware of his rights, duties and social responsibilities to create better society. Various thinkers have defined Civics as under:

- **According to F.J Gold**, civics is a discipline of knowledge, which deals with institutions, habits, activities and sentiments, which provide an individual irrespective of gender, with a moral force to pay his duties and to enjoy a sense of belongingness with an organization.
- **E.M White** defines Civics as a useful discipline of human knowledge, which deals with every aspect of human life covering his past, present and future aspects at local, national and global levels.
- **Patrick Gaddis** declares Civics as a study of Civic life and its related issues.
- “Civics is the study of the theoretical, political, and practical aspects of citizenship, as well as its rights and duties.” -**John J. Patrick** (Author of “Civic Education in the United States”)

- “Civics refers to the study of the role of citizens and the functioning of society, where individuals are prepared to responsibly contribute to public life through knowledge and skills.” – **Sidney Hook** (Philosopher and Education Theorist)
- “A proper civics education enables every citizen to understand and support their government and make decisions for the public good, ensuring the survival of democracy.”
-**Thomas Jefferson** (3rd U.S. President, Founding Father)
- “Civics is a social science dealing with the rights and duties of citizens.” – **Merriam-Webster Dictionary**
- “Civics encompasses the study of citizenship, government, and the workings of democracy, focusing on equipping individuals to fulfill their role in democratic governance.” - **National Council for the Social Studies** (NCSS)

Each of these definitions highlights different aspects of civics, emphasizing its importance in educating citizens about their rights, responsibilities, and the functioning of government.

Nature and Characteristics of Civics

Here are some key points about the nature and characteristics of Civics:

- **Educational Focus:** Civics is primarily educational, aimed at teaching individuals about their roles, rights, and responsibilities within a society or government. It helps students understand the principles and functioning of democracy.
- **Rights and Responsibilities:** It emphasizes the balance between individual rights and civic responsibilities, highlighting how citizens should act to protect their freedoms while contributing to the common good.
- **Government Structure:** Civics explores the structure and functions of government institutions, including the legislative, executive, and judicial branches, and how they interact to form a cohesive governance system.
- **Political Participation:** It covers various forms of political participation, such as voting advocacy, and public service, encouraging active involvement in democratic processes.
- **Legal Framework:** Civics includes understanding the legal system, including laws, regulations, and the constitution, and how they affect individuals and society.

- **Civic Engagement:** It promotes civic engagement by encouraging activities that contribute to community development and societal well-being, such as volunteering and community organizing.
- **Ethical Considerations:** Civics involves discussions about ethical issues and moral responsibilities related to citizenship, such as social justice, equity, and environmental stewardship.
- **Historical Context:** It often includes historical perspectives on how civic practices and institutions have evolved, providing insight into the development of democratic principles and governance.
- **Critical Thinking:** Civics encourages critical thinking and analysis of political and social issues, helping individuals to make informed decisions and form reasoned opinions.
- **Cultural and Global Awareness;** It fosters an understanding of cultural diversity and global interconnections, highlighting the importance of respecting different viewpoints and participating in global citizenship.

These characteristics collectively define civics as a field dedicated to preparing individuals to be informed, responsible, and active members of their communities and democracies.